Philippines, Vietnam, Malaysia, and Brunei. And, according to Beijing, those countries, not China, are behaving ‘provocatively’.

Chinese spokesmen have asserted that fifteenth and sixteenth century documents from the Ming Dynasty show that China ruled over the entire South China Sea. But nothing could be further from the truth. The Ming emperors paid only scant attention to maritime ventures. During China’s brief historical stint as a sea power in the fifteenth century, an explorer called Zheng He sailed with his fleet to South and Southeast Asia, the Indian subcontinent, the Arab peninsula, and even as far as the coast of East Africa. The detailed accounts and maps, which were compiled by Zheng’s aide Ma Huan, list more than 700 place names in Southeast Asia and the Indian Ocean, including remote islands in the Andamans, the Nicobars, Maldives, and Lakshadweep.[29]

Chinese cartographers were aware of the existence and location of the Spratlys, and Ma Huan mentions them as well, but not in such great detail as other places he documents in his logbooks. The reason is quite simple: the Spratlys are not islands, but treacherous shoals and underwater reefs, which the ancient navies sailed around to avoid being shipwrecked. But that has not prevented China from making its spurious assertions—and, most recently, from constructing artificial islands on top of those shoals and reefs to, literally speaking, cement its claims. Any opposing view would be branded as an interference in China’s internal affairs.

In July 2016, the Permanent Court of Arbitration in The Hague, in response to a complaint lodged by the Philippines, found that China has no credible ‘historic rights’ over the South China Sea in accordance with the UN Convention on the Law of the Sea (UNCLOS). It said that there was no evidence that China ever exercised such rights of an exclusive sovereign nature. The government in Beijing responded angrily, calling the ruling a ‘farce’ and declared that China’s territorial and marine rights in the seas would not be affected by the ruling.[30] A strongly worded editorial in the official newspaper *Renmin Ribao* (‘the people’s daily’) asserted that the tribunal had ‘ignored basic truths’ and ‘trampled’ on international laws and therefore ‘the Chinese government and the Chinese people firmly [oppose] the ruling and will neither acknowledge it nor accept it’.[31]

There may not be another war in the Himalayas, but China’s similarly intransigent attitude and behaviour in the South China Sea could well lead